

Seniors United Now

Position Paper

Subject: DriveAble and SIMARD MD Test

Position:

Part of SUN's mission is to inform our members on current issues that may affect them. Sometimes these issues, that arise, may be contentious. We do invite speakers and allow them to present a point of view that may not be universally accepted

We have invited Dr B Dobbs and B Carstensen to speak at the December 4th meeting. Our invitation does not mean that SUN supports DriveAble or the SIMARD MD test., rather it was to provide them with an opportunity to inform our members of what they offer and what is involved with the tests.

We understand that cognitive impairment is a growing problem within the senior population, as a result of dementia, heart disease, diabetes and other contributing factors. Our members value their independence, which includes the right to drive. The question is- how is that right to be determined, and by whom?

Cognitive impairment tests, identified as mmse (mini mental state exam) Trail Test, Dem Tect Test have been used for years and there is research to support their results. We understand that the SIMARD MD (screen for the identification of the medically at risk driver) is just an improvement of the Dem Tect.

We are not in a position to make any comments on the accuracy of the tests. This is up to the people involved in the process, including those responsible for revoking a driver's licence. These tests were developed for the use of Physicians, Driver examiners and licensers.

Our position is that we advocate for seniors and our mission is to ensure that they are being fairly and equitably treated. Our objective is to assess any risks to their independence. The current protocol for the testing process seems to be flawed and not working as it was intended. It is our intention to advocate for change as the actual process is further explained, therefore the invitation. The cost of these tests is another issue of concern. It is currently paid for by the senior, who does not order them. Payment should be by the initiator, not the senior. Quite possibly this should be a government funded program.

November 30, 2012